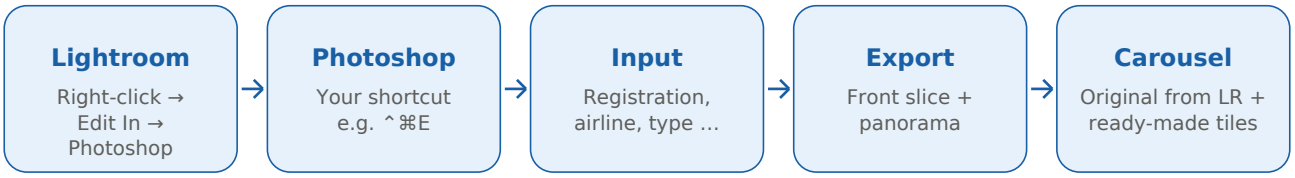
Spotting Export

Setup guide for Lightroom Classic and Photoshop on the Mac. From an edited panorama to a ready-to-post Instagram carousel with one shortcut – runs fully local, no AI, no internet, no subscription.

Idea & workflow: **@shutterview.aviation** · built with Claude

What it does



After the shortcut the script reads the format from the image (8x5 → 2, 12x5 → 3, 16x5 → 4, 20x5 → 5 slices) and opens an input window. It then finds or creates the aircraft type folder, saves the slice in flight direction and the panorama via “Save for Web”, lets Lightroom export the original into the same folder and finally builds the complete carousel.

Result (example)

```
Aviation/
  B747/
    D-ABYN-Lufthansa-FRA-25L-ShortFinal/
      20260927_IMG1234_D-ABYN-Front.jpg          ← slice in flight direction
      20260927_IMG1234_D-ABYN-Panorama-16x5.jpg  ← full panorama
      20260927_IMG1234_D-ABYN-16x9.jpg           ← original from Lightroom
      Carousel/01.jpg … 06.jpg                   ← ready-to-post tiles
```

Folder name: **registration-airline-airport-runway-extra**. File names: **capture date + original name + registration**.

Package contents

File	Purpose
install.sh	Installs everything with one command
spotting_export.py	Controls the workflow
dialog.js	The input window
ps_slice_export.jsx	Slicing, export and carousel in Photoshop
Spotting-Export.jsx	Photoshop menu item (File → Scripts) for your shortcut
starter.applescript	Small launcher that runs your shortcut
SpottingExport.lrplugin	Lightroom plugin that exports the original
Font-Preview.jsx	Shows candidate fonts for the info tile in Photoshop
carousel_icons	Icons and divider for the info tile
config.json	Settings (template)

Installation step by step

Requirements

- Mac with Adobe Lightroom Classic and Adobe Photoshop (tested with Photoshop 2026).
- About 20 minutes for the one-time setup. No coding skills needed.

Step 1 – Check Python

1. Open Terminal (⌘ + Space, type “Terminal”).
2. Enter this command and press Return:

```
python3 --version
```

If a version number appears, you’re ready. If macOS offers to install the developer tools instead, confirm and wait.

Step 2 – Create the shortcut

1. Open the **Shortcuts** app.
2. **Shortcuts → Settings…** (⌘ + comma) → tab **Advanced** → enable **Allow Running Scripts**.
3. Click **All Shortcuts** and the **+** button.
4. Rename it to **Spotting Export** (click the name at the top). Remember the name – install.sh asks for it.
5. Search for **Shell** on the right and add **Run Shell Script** by double-clicking.
6. Delete the sample text in the action and **paste** (don’t type) this line:

```
/usr/bin/python3 ~/Library/Application\ Support/SpottingExport/spotting_export.py
```

The backslash before the space in “Application Support” is intended. When typing, macOS may replace straight quotes with curly ones – that’s why pasting is safer.

Step 3 – Install the package

1. Unzip the file in your Downloads folder.
2. In Terminal:

```
cd ~/Downloads/Spotting-Export-EN
bash install.sh
```

The installer asks for your export folder (folder picker), the name shown next to the © on the info tile, your Instagram handle and the name of your shortcut (press Return for “Spotting Export”). It also copies the Photoshop menu item to `/Applications/Adobe Photoshop 2026/Presets/Scripts/` and asks for your Mac password for that. “replacing existing signature” is harmless.

Step 4 – Photoshop menu item and keyboard shortcut

1. Only if the installer could not copy the menu item, copy it manually in Terminal:

```
sudo cp Spotting-Export.jsx "/Applications/Adobe Photoshop 2026/Presets/Scripts/"
```

2. Restart Photoshop.
3. Test once with an open image: **File → Scripts → Spotting-Export**.
4. Open **Edit → Keyboard Shortcuts…**, set “Shortcuts for” to **Application Menus**.
5. Expand **File**, scroll to **Scripts → Spotting-Export**, click the field and press your combination, e.g. **⌃⌘E** (Control + Command + E). Photoshop warns you if it’s already in use. Photoshop may display it as “Ctrl+⌘+E” – that’s the same.
6. Confirm with **OK**.

Don’t assign a keyboard shortcut in the Shortcuts app itself – the Photoshop shortcut is more reliable.

Step 5 – Set up Lightroom

1. Quit Lightroom completely with **⌘Q** and start it again.
2. **File → Plug-in Manager**: select “Spotting Export”. Status must be “Installed and running”. If it’s missing, click **Add**, press ⇧⌘G, paste `~/Library/Application Support/Adobe/Lightroom/Modules` and choose **SpottingExport.lrplugin**.
3. Check: a few seconds after the catalog has loaded, “**Spotting Export ready**” appears briefly.
4. Recommended: **Settings → External Editing** for Photoshop: TIFF, 8 bit, sRGB.

Optional – your own Lightroom export preset: save your export settings as a preset in the export dialog and enter its name under **lightroom_export_preset**. All fixed naming parts are kept; the script only fills the “Custom Text” field.

Step 6 – Choose your export folder

Option A (easiest): click **Change export folder…** in the input window and pick the main folder in which your aircraft type folders (A320, B747 …) live. The choice is saved.

Option B: enter the path in the config. Open it with:

```
open -e "$HOME/Library/Application Support/SpottingExport/config.json"
```

Select the folder in Finder, **⌥⌘C** copies its path. Paste it between the quotes of **export_root**, **remove all backslashes** and save with ⌘S.

> “Invalid \escape” means there is still a backslash in the path. Quotes must be straight (") and the comma at the end of the line must stay.

Step 7 – Spots (optional)

If a photo has GPS data and was taken at one of your spots, airport and runway are filled in automatically. Add each spot under **spots** and set **"active": true**:

```
{ "active": true, "name": "FRA visitor terrace", "lat": 50.0379, "lon": 8.5622,
  "radius_m": 1500, "airport": "FRA", "runway_left": "25C", "runway_right": "07C" }
```

runway_left / runway_right: the runway in use when the aircraft flies to the left / right in your photo.

Step 8 – First run

1. In Lightroom: right-click a panorama → **Edit In → Edit in Adobe Photoshop**.
2. In Photoshop: press your shortcut.
3. On the first run macOS asks for permissions (control Photoshop/Lightroom, folder access) – click **Allow**.
4. Enter the data, click **OK**.
5. Lightroom shows “exporting…” and “done”, Photoshop builds the carousel, a “Done” notification appears.

The input window

Field	Note
Registration	Required. Used exactly as typed.
Airline	Leave empty for a known registration – filled in from your history.
Aircraft type	Sub-types are shortened (A340-600 → A340, 777-300ER → B777). Missing folders are created; “Boeing 777”, “777” and “B777” count as the same.
Airport	Suggested from your spot or the last image.
Runway	Leave empty = value of your spot for the chosen direction.
Direction	right → the right slice is saved as front, left → the left one.
Format	Detected from the image and preselected, can be changed.
Extra	Optional, appended to the folder name (e.g. ShortFinal).

Settings in config.json

Setting	Meaning
export_root	Main export folder (empty = asked on first run)
lightroom_export_preset	Name of your Lightroom export preset, empty = built-in settings
lr_custom_text_pattern	Custom Text: {registration} {airline} {airport} {runway} {type} {extra} {format}
original_suffix	auto = aspect ratio of the Lightroom crop (e.g. 16x9)
prefix_capture_date	true = capture date (YYYYMMDD) in front of the file name
quit_photoshop	true = quit Photoshop at the end
front_slice	flight_direction or against_flight_direction
flag_original	true = flag the original as Pick
type_mapping	Group types, e.g. {"A319": "A320"}
carousel_enabled	true = build the carousel tiles
carousel_width / _height	Tile size, default 1620 × 2025
carousel_blur / _darken	Background blur and darkening of the info tile
carousel_divider	graphic = divider with double bar, line = simple line
carousel_font	Font of the info tile (PostScript name)
copyright / instagram	Shown on the info tile
spots	Your spotting locations (step 7)

Font check: in Photoshop **File → Scripts → Browse…** → **Font-Preview.jsx** shows the candidates installed on your Mac. SF Pro must be installed from developer.apple.com/fonts to be usable in Photoshop.

Troubleshooting

Problem	Solution
Photoshop error 8800	Usually an old version is installed: delete old folders, unzip again, run install.sh.
Stops after switching to Lightroom	Did “Spotting Export ready” appear? Check the Plug-in Manager, restart Lightroom with ⌘Q. Fallback: Library → Plug-in Extras → Spotting Export – run now.
“Invalid \escape”	Remove backslashes from the path in config.json (step 6).
Shortcut does nothing	Assign it in Photoshop (step 4). The shortcut name must match the one entered in install.sh (saved in shortcut_name.txt).
No entry under File → Scripts	Copy Spotting-Export.jsx (step 4) and restart Photoshop.
Asks for Accessibility	Only for the fallback if Lightroom doesn’t pick up the job: allow Shortcuts under System Settings → Privacy & Security → Accessibility.

Log file

```
cat ~/Library/Application\ Support/SpottingExport/spotting_export.log
```

Updating

1. Delete old “Spotting-Export...” folders and ZIP files in Downloads.
2. Unzip the new package and run **bash install.sh** (your settings are kept).
3. Restart Lightroom and Photoshop.

Free for personal use, shared as-is without warranty. Adobe Lightroom Classic and Photoshop are not included. Idea & workflow: @shutterview.aviation · built with Claude.